



Activity Report
2024-2025

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1. ABOUT ABWCI

The Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry (ABWCI) is a global chamber for women in business, empowering them through a supportive ecosystem, fostering equity, and inclusive prosperity for a thriving society. ABWCI is a membership-based network, connecting women across diverse sectors.

Registered as a Not for Profit under Section 8 of the Indian Companies Act, 2013, ABWCI was officially launched in 2021; with the aim to empower, engage, and educate women in business, while advocating for policies that foster a collaborative ecosystem globally.

ABWCI celebrates and enables women's business acumen & ambition by connecting members to investors, incubators, accelerators, traditional donors, thought leaders, academia, professional development resources, and relevant opportunities.

The primary focus areas are:

- Access to Market • Access to Finance
- Access to Technology
- Access to Entrepreneurial Ecosystems

Recognitions

- Member of UNFPA's Equity 2030 Alliance
- Knowledge partner of the UNGCNI
- Knowledge partner of the G20/W20 in 2023
- Listed on the Social Stock Exchange (NSE, India)

ABWCI's value proposition lies in the multifaceted approach to empower women entrepreneurs globally, fostering connections, providing opportunities, and advocating for supportive ecosystems that contribute to economic growth and societal well-being. The Chamber is committed to creating a robust community of women entrepreneurs; providing them with opportunities to access investment capital, trade networks & entrepreneurial education; and advocating for policies resulting in women - centric entrepreneurial ecosystems worldwide. ABWCI has representatives in over 40 Countries and with a membership base in over 50 Countries.

OUR IMPACT

1,50,000
+

Direct and
Indirect Members

50+

Business
Associations &
Women Networks

55

MoUs with Business
Associations,
Educational
Institutions,
Incubation Centers

Outreach
events

2. Activities undertaken in FY 2024-25

The year marked a pivotal phase for ABWCI as we advanced our mission of empowering women entrepreneurs through access to markets, finance, technology, and entrepreneurial ecosystems. Our focus this year was on building inclusive platforms that enabled women at the grassroots as well as in emerging sectors to scale their enterprises and strengthen their leadership. Flagship initiatives such as *Grameen Heroes* – a rural adaptation of the Shark Tank model – and *Women Entrepreneurs for Women Entrepreneurs (WE4WE)* demonstrated how innovation, mentorship, and structured support can accelerate women-led development in rural and tribal regions. These programs not only created sustainable livelihoods but also showcased how women entrepreneurs, when provided the right networks and opportunities, can drive local and national economic transformation.

At the same time, ABWCI invested in strengthening digital enablement and global outreach for women-led enterprises. Capacity-building sessions across five states equipped women with tools to enter domestic and cross-border e-commerce markets, expanding their vision from local enterprises to global brands.

Strategic partnerships with corporates, academia, and international organizations expanded our influence, positioning ABWCI as a connector of women entrepreneurs to opportunities and networks worldwide. Through participation in high-impact forums and collaborations,

ABWCI reinforced its role as a catalyst for inclusive economic growth. As we move forward, we are committed to scaling impact, launching accelerators and mentorship programs, and building a globally connected, future-ready network of women entrepreneurs shaping resilient and inclusive economies.

✦ Grameen Heroes

Grameen Heroes, was an adoption of shark tank in rural setting. The initiative was implemented by ABWCI and funded by HeroMotoCorp (HMCL). where women are not passive beneficiaries, but innovators shaping rural economic growth.

Implemented across Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Haryana, Gujarat, and Andhra Pradesh, the mission was clear: identify, support, and scale promising women-led micro- enterprises in rural India.



From Outreach to Opportunity

1,500+ touchpoints through multilingual outreach, CSO partnerships, and HMCL plant networks.

964 shortlisted applications across diverse sectors:

- Agriculture & Allied Activities
- Traditional & Skill-Based Enterprises
- Handicrafts
- Micro Retail & Services

Multi-level screening on business viability, scalability, and clarity of vision.

The Selection Journey

- State-Level Pitches: 147 women pitched in Jaipur, Vadodara, Gurugram, Dehradun, and an online round for Andhra Pradesh.
- National Pitch: Top 35 selected women from 5 states were invited for Grand finale, New Delhi on July 4, 2025 – many travelling outside their districts for the first time.

For each of the state level pitch event and grand finale, the jury comprised of distinguished members from social entrepreneurship, CSR Women leadership and grassroots innovation.



Recognition, Impact & Inclusion

The 35 finalists showcased enterprises rooted in local realities yet brimming with innovation:

- Eco-wood products from pine needles •
- Ayurvedic processing units
- Digital logistics solutions
- Food ventures run by trans women •
- Sustainable manufacturing



- Wellness-based enterprises

Grant Awards

- ₹1,00,000 each to the top 20 entrepreneurs
- ₹25,000 each to the remaining 15 finalists

More than grants, it was an investment in belief, leadership, and possibility.

Inclusion was at the heart of the program, with transgender and differently abled entrepreneurs among the top scorers.

Participants gained:

- Expert mentorship & capacity building
- Market exposure & business visibility
- Leadership skills & renewed self-worth



Impact in Their Own Words

"I no longer say I run a small business – I say I am building a company."

Grameen Heroes proved that when opportunity meets vision, rural women can become the architects of their communities' economic transformation.



✦ WE4WE

Women Entrepreneurs for Women Entrepreneurs (WE4WE) Project
Unlocking the Potential of Women Entrepreneurs to Lead Economic and Social Change in Rural India

The WE4WE Project is a joint initiative of Passing Gifts Private Limited (PGPL) and

ABWCI, designed to accelerate women-led development by strengthening women-led Farmer Producer Organizations (FPOs) in the tribal and rural regions of Odisha.

In FY 2024–25, ABWCI worked closely with four women-led FPOs comprising of more than 3000+ farmer members in Koraput district, engaged in cultivating turmeric, ginger, and small millets. The project addressed both economic empowerment and social development, contributing to poverty alleviation and rural upliftment.

Key Focus Areas & Achievements •

Sustainable Market Linkages:

- ABWCI facilitated structured buyer-seller interactions, resulting in confirmed procurement contracts for turmeric with two FPOs. These contracts created

predictable income streams and strengthened the FPOs' market presence.

- Mentorship of Women board members of FPOs.
- Tailored capacity-building sessions were conducted for the FPOs' Board of Directors and office bearers, supported by experienced women entrepreneurs as mentors. The mentorship focused on:
 - Learning from journeys of successful women entrepreneurs
 - Enhancing visibility via digital and social platforms
 - Building readiness for export-oriented markets



This initiative exemplified how women-led organizations, with the right tools and networks, can catalyze economic and social transformation. By empowering women's leadership in agriculture, WE4WE promotes financial independence, stronger decision-making, and inclusive development in tribal and rural India.



✦ Capacity Building & Digital Enablement

ABWCI through a series of structured training sessions, participants from 5 states were

guided through comprehensive learning modules, covering every step from setting up their online store, managing product listings, pricing and logistics, handling customer engagement and ensuring compliance with platform standards.

These sessions were designed to be highly practical, allowing women entrepreneurs to apply their learnings in real time and take their businesses live on digital platforms.

In addition to domestic e-commerce readiness, the sessions introduced participants to the possibilities of cross-border trade, encouraging them to explore international markets and position their products for global consumers. This exposure broadened their vision of what their businesses could achieve, turning local enterprises into potential global brands.

By combining onboarding support, skill-based training, and international exposure, this initiative created a strong foundation for a new generation of digitally savvy women entrepreneurs ready to compete, grow, and expand beyond geographical boundaries.



3. Partnerships

ABWCI continued to strengthen its position as a global platform for women entrepreneurs by building impactful collaborations, engaging with thought leaders, and participating in forums that promote women-led development. These partnerships and engagements have played a crucial role in advancing our mission of creating inclusive and sustainable entrepreneurial ecosystems.

★ Ekhos

ABWCI partnered with Ekhos to connect women entrepreneurs across India and Latin America. Together, we co-hosted GIBEF 2025, 18th and 19th of February: Vishwa Yuvak Kendra, New Delhi. a global forum that brought together policymakers, investors, and women business leaders to discuss inclusive growth, circular economy models, and cross-border collaboration. This partnership has significantly expanded ABWCI's international footprint and opened doors for global market linkages.



★ Jubilant Bhartia Foundation

ABWCI collaborated with JBF to design multi-stakeholder models for social impact and entrepreneurship ecosystem building. The partnership focuses on knowledge creation, experiential learning, and supporting women entrepreneurs in accessing corporate value chains, laying the groundwork for long-term impact.



★ Womenlines

Partnered with Womenlines, a global digital magazine ranked among the top women empowerment platforms, to amplify ABWCI's initiatives and success stories. This collaboration helped extend ABWCI's reach to a wider audience and inspired more women to join the entrepreneurial movement.



★ Asian School of Business:

ABWCI engaged with ASB to strengthen industry-academia collaboration and foster entrepreneurship among students. Through mentorship sessions and knowledge sharing, the partnership aims to build a pipeline of future-ready women entrepreneurs and leaders.



4. Networking & Outreach

ABWCI actively engaged in high-impact networking forums and global outreach initiatives during this period, amplifying its mission of empowering women entrepreneurs.

★ Her Courage Leaders Summit 2025

Parul Soni, as a Mentor and Co-Partner, actively contributed to the HER Courage Leaders Summit 2025, fostering dialogue on women's leadership and empowerment. The summit became a celebration of fearless women leaders, amplifying inspiring stories, showcasing meaningful collaborations, and sparking new ideas for advancing gender equality. This participation reinforced ABWCI's commitment to nurturing courageous leadership and building a strong global community of women entrepreneurs.



Parul Soni

MENTOR AND
SUPPORTING PARTNER
Founder and Global Managing
Partner-Thinkthrough
Consulting
Founder & Secretary General
ABWCI

★ Beyond Barriers 2024

ABWCI partnered for Yukkee's Beyond Barriers 2024, proudly supporting this powerful platform focused on investing in women for a sustainable future. The event brought together changemakers, industry leaders, and innovators to address challenges, share success stories, and chart actionable steps toward breaking systemic barriers. By lending its voice and network, ABWCI highlighted the importance of collaboration in creating inclusive ecosystems where women in business can thrive and lead impactful ventures.



★ ABWCI at ALEAP's International Conference

ABWCI participated in ALEAP's International Conference (March 7-9, 2025, Vijayawada), with Vidya Manmohan, and Savita Sethi, Director of Programmes of ABWCI, sharing valuable insights on fostering sustainable, women-led enterprises. Their sessions explored pathways for scaling innovation, strengthening inclusion in global value chains, and building robust networks for women entrepreneurs. The conference was a significant milestone in promoting cross-country collaboration and collective action to empower women-led businesses.



✦ Panel Discussion: Borderless Business Opportunities

As part of the Together We Grow initiative, ABWCI partnered as the Ecosystem Collaborator for a high-impact panel discussion on **'Borderless Business Opportunities'** held in Bangalore. The session brought together global women leaders, including representatives from Nepal, Sri Lanka, the Philippines, Kyrgyz Republic, and Canada, alongside Indian trade experts.

Moderated by ABWCI's Founder & Secretary General, Mr. Parul Soni, the panel explored practical strategies to boost cross-border trade for women-led businesses. The discussion offered participants actionable insights on market access, policy alignment, and collaboration models that can strengthen international trade ecosystems.

An inspiring exchange of ideas, the session reinforced the importance of global partnerships and knowledge-sharing in creating pathways for women entrepreneurs to scale their ventures beyond national boundaries.



✦ Advaita Women Entrepreneur Awards 2024

At the Advaita Women Entrepreneur Awards 2024 in New Delhi, ABWCI's CEO represented the organization on a dynamic panel discussion alongside the Founders of Women Inspiring Network and New Age Mompreneurs, with the Chief Guest, Founder of Momwearsprada.

The engaging conversation on "Viksit Bharat: The Role of Women Entrepreneurs" spotlighted the transformative impact of women entrepreneurs in shaping India's growth story. The panel emphasized how innovation, leadership, and enterprises can accelerate economic development and drive social change.

ABWCI's participation not only elevated its voice at a national platform but also strengthened connections with ecosystem leaders committed to building an inclusive, women-led economy.

5. Way Forward

As ABWCI moves into the next phase of its journey, we remain steadfast in our mission to strengthen the global ecosystem for women entrepreneurs. Building on the success of initiatives like Project Grameen Heroes and WE4WE, we aim to create even greater impact through the following priorities:

- **Scaling Impact:** Expanding our programs to reach more women entrepreneurs across rural and underserved regions, enabling them to access markets, finance, and mentorship at scale.
- **Capacity Building & Digital Enablement:** Organizing targeted capacity-building initiatives to digitally empower women entrepreneurs, equipping them with tools to grow their businesses, embrace e-commerce, and access global market opportunities.
- **Women Accelerator Program:** Launching a dedicated accelerator to support women entrepreneurs with structured guidance, resources, and investor connect opportunities to fast-track their growth.
- **Mentorship & Upskilling:** Designing robust mentoring programs to nurture women in their entrepreneurial journeys, with a special focus on upskilling and leadership development.
- **Strategic Collaborations:** Deepening partnerships with corporates, multilateral agencies, and academic institutions to co-create sustainable, women-led economic growth models.

Our vision for the coming year is clear to create a globally connected, future-ready network of women entrepreneurs who are digitally empowered, equipped to lead innovation, build resilient businesses, and shape a more inclusive and prosperous economy.

Join us in our digital journey



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